

Precious Comment: Central Bank Gold Purchases: Less Slow Than We Thought, Still Likely to Reaccelerate

- We are updating our GS nowcast of central bank gold purchases because, since August 2025, it has begun to systematically undershoot flows implied by physical balances in London. Our updated 12-month moving average (12MMA) nowcast stands at 50 tonnes/month in March compared with 29 tonnes/month under the previous specification ([Exhibit 1](#)).¹
- We expect central bank purchases to pick up and average 60 tonnes/month through 2026. Our [GS central bank survey](#) points to strong underlying interest in gold, and recent geopolitical developments are likely to reinforce diversification over time — both for central banks and private investors. As a result, we remain constructive on gold and reiterate our \$5,400/toz target for end-2026. That said, we are more cautious in the near term. Gold's high liquidity makes it a natural source of cash if private investors face liquidity needs — for example, if equity markets sell off amid higher rates and weaker growth expectations linked to geopolitical risks.
- We refer the reader to our [Gold Market Primer](#) for a detailed description of our GS nowcast of central bank purchases. In short, our GS nowcast infers reported and unreported buying from UK customs data because London OTC is the primary venue where sovereign buyers transact. The UK produces no deliverable gold — there are no significant gold mines or accredited refineries producing the London-standard bars — so all gold traded in London must be imported. Once imported, gold has two main paths. If it remains in the UK, it is held in London vaults — for ETFs, the Bank of England, or other institutions. If it leaves, it is either shipped to Switzerland to be recast into smaller bars for retail demand or transferred to sovereign vaults abroad. Consistent with this, our nowcast is constructed as the sum of (1) UK exports of gold bars to the world excluding Switzerland and (2) the portion of UK exports to Switzerland that we identify as central bank demand.
- Since we infer central bank demand directly from UK trade data, the key assumption is that central bank gold flows are recorded in UK export data despite international guidelines recommending excluding sovereign gold from trade statistics. Testing this assumption is simple. Once imported, gold must either be exported or remain in London vaults, so UK net exports should match London vault outflows. Historically, they did. The close match implied that central

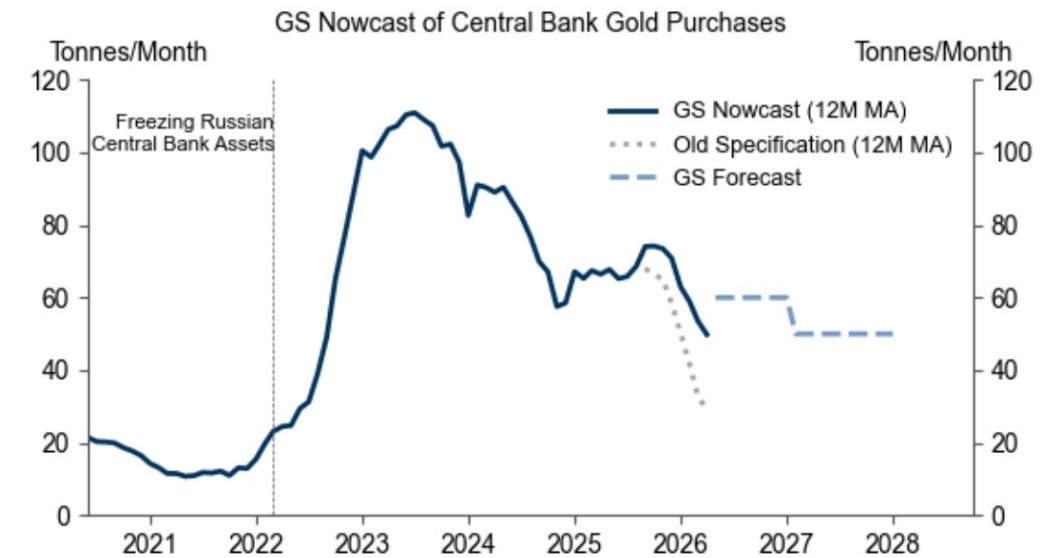
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¹ Our updated GS central bank nowcast implies gold purchases of 66 tonnes in January (vs. 12 tonnes previously), 41 tonnes in February (vs. 2 tonnes), and 18 tonnes in March (vs. 13 tonnes).

bank gold flows were being recorded in UK trade statistics in practice.

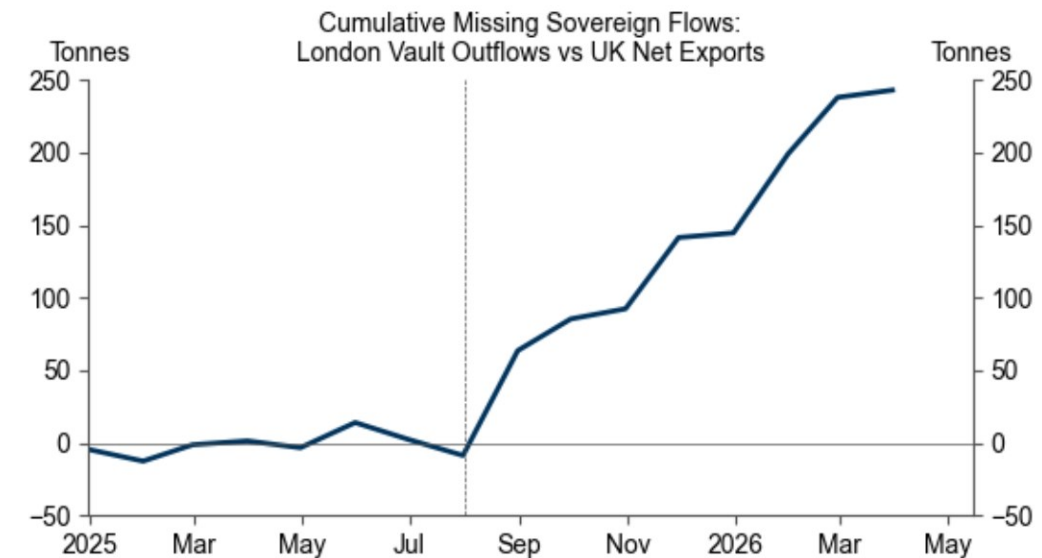
- Since August 2025, this assumption has weakened. London vault data now show gold leaving, but UK trade data no longer fully reflect these outflows.² This suggests that some portion of sovereign transactions is no longer being recorded ([Exhibit 2](#)). We therefore adjust our nowcast by adding the discrepancy between London vault outflows and UK net exports as unrecorded sovereign gold flows.

Exhibit 1: We Update Our Nowcast of Central Bank Gold Purchases, Because...



Source: UK HMRC, Swiss Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: ... A Consistent Gap Between London Vault Outflows and UK Net Exports Suggests Our GS Nowcast Had Been Undershooting Central Bank Gold Purchases Since August 2025



Source: LBMA, UK HMRC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

² Classification is at the discretion of customs officers. Transactions between a non-sovereign and a central bank – as often happens in the London OTC market – can be harder to identify as sovereign gold, and may still be recorded in trade statistics.

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